Coming from the highest power in the land, a clearer statement could not have been made that SSNCo was paying for its association with VOC. Having forced the company to take coercive action against VOC, the government continued to blame him for its woes.

Following the audience to the deputation, Governor Lawley had however declared that 'the impression was wrong that the Government was against the Swadeshi Company'. An editorial in *The Hindu*, tactically perhaps, chose to take the government's officially stated position at face value. Endorsing his sentiment, it said, 'Let us hope that the assurance of impartiality which fell from the lips of H.E. Sir Arthur Lawley in his reply to the Tinnevelly Deputation, will introduce a welcome change in the tactics of local officers.'[45] The daily also noted that Wynch had assured a prominent director of the company that he bore no ill will towards the company. In this context, an evidently well-informed correspondent of *The Hindu* remarked, 'Confidence is being slowly restored and people are now getting convinced that the policy of the Government cannot be to obstruct the Company, whatever some individual officers might do.' But he continued wryly, 'As it is, we have to be thankful to His Excellency the Governor for verbal declarations of neutrality' but added that he would not even 'express disapproval of the clearly hostile attitude of Mr Ashe'.[46] Clutching at straws, the transfer of Mr Ashe was considered 'a real blessing', a sign of the changed attitude of the government.[47]

However, it soon became clear that this was a mirage. The governor's words were an empty promise, never meant to be kept. The juggernaut would roll until the company was crushed.

The same *Hindu* which had expressed some hope at Lawley's words soon exposed how BI was working hand in glove with the government. Drawing on the admissions made under oath by Varaprasadam Pillai (in the security case against the vakils), *The Hindu*'s correspondent stated that only the residents of Tuticorin knew the extent of BI's underhand dealings. Its agents were not only 'solicitously advising the Swadeshi shippers to wind up the